This soup is a beautiful cool, pale green, flecked with mint and bright, skinned beans. Do not reheat once you have mixed in the yogurt, as it may curdle.

fava bean and mint soup

SERVES 4 **PREP** 30 MINS **COOK** 25 MINS **FREEZE** UP TO 3 MONTHS AT THE END OF STEP 2

1lb (450g) fava beans (shelled weight), thawed if frozen
1 onion, chopped
1 rib celery, thinly sliced
2 tbsp butter
2 tbsp short-grain rice
1 generous sprig summer savory or thyme
1 quart (1 liter) chicken or vegetable stock
salt and pepper
4oz (110g) Greek yogurt
handful of fresh mint leaves, chopped
4 small sprigs of mint
paprika or cayenne pepper, to serve

1 If the beans are fresh, drop them into a pot of boiling water and simmer for 1 minute. Drain and run under the cold tap. Then, whether using fresh or frozen, skin each bean by slitting the tough outer skin with a fingernail or a small sharp knife and squeezing out the bright green beanlet inside. Take about one-eighth, chop coarsely, and set aside.

2 Over low heat in a covered pan, sweat the onion and celery gently in the butter for 10 minutes, or until very tender. Add the rice and savory or thyme and cook for another minute, uncovered. Now add the unchopped beans, 3¾ cups of the stock, salt, and pepper; bring to a boil and simmer for 10 minutes, or until the rice is tender. Remove the herbs then blend in batches, adding more stock if you want a looser consistency.

3 Shortly before serving, reheat thoroughly, then remove from the heat. Stir a tablespoonful of the yogurt into the reserved chopped beans and the mint. Mix in the remaining yogurt, a tablespoon at a time, until it is all added. Taste and adjust the seasoning and serve while still warm, floating a sprig of mint and a light dusting of paprika or cayenne on the surface of each bowl.